BOOKS

Southern Saga

The Tamils *by* ***Nirmala Lakshman*** *is a detailed look at the making of a community*

How can we say where any English-language text stands in the literature on the Tamil people, history and language? If every Tamil patriot is to be believed, it has all been written much better in Tamil before. Still, Nirmala Lakshman's *The Tamils: A Portrait of a Community* is a book every dutiful native will read. Though her introduction hints at a personal and anecdotal approach, the narrative is grounded in the solid research of earlier scholars and mostly follows a conventional path. The author begins with prehistoric artefacts and goes on to the rise, fall and conflicts of the great dynasties. She covers religious movements, military forays, social policies and literary and cultural flowering, and she keeps her tone fair. She points out, for example, that social oppression was not incidental or anomalous, though the just conduct of the ancient Tamil rulers was legendary. The seeds of disparity were sown in town fortifications that left tribal and rural populations prey to rival chieftains and marauders, or land endowments to Brahmins, which remained untaxed while the rulers burdened farmers and traders.

Later chapters cover the entry of the Delhi Sultanate, which left Tamilakam fragmented and impoverished, and the rule of the Vijayanagaras, Nayakas and Marathas. The abiding presence of Christianity and Islam is covered, as well as the impact of many colonial powers, peaking in the unrelenting predation of the East India Company and the British Raj. The text surveys resistance and revolts against the Raj from Marudu Pandyan of the rebel proclamation up to V.O. Chidambaram Pillai and Subramania Bharati, who almost lived to see their cause prevail. The self-respect movement is a matter of pride for Tamils, but the author does not shy away from exploring the pressure of persistent caste loyalties post-Independence.

THE NARRATIVE IS GROUNDED IN THE SOLID RESEARCH OF EARLIER SCHOLARS AND MOSTLY FOLLOWS A CONVENTIONAL PATH

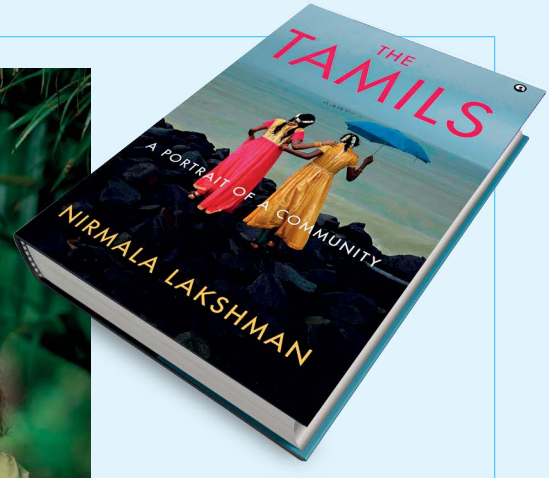
Aleph was savvy in handing this huge task to a writer from Indian journalism's first family—a book by Dr Lakshman will undoubtedly sell itself. But having done that, the publisher has left her to soldier on by herself. The book contains absolutely everything, and a project of that scope deserved the support of rigorous editing and supplementary graphics. To a reader attempting to absorb the interwoven trajectories of the Pallavas, Cholas, Pandyas and Cheras over 2,000 years, a few maps, timelines and genealogical charts would have been helpful. The photographs are closely connected to the text, but too few for a 400-page book.

In any case, a historian's work is never done. Shortly after this book was launched, archaeologists announced that the earliest evidence of the Iron Age was recorded from what is now Tamil Nadu. Even the ancient past of Tamilakam, it appears, is not yet past, and another book will come along soon. ■

–Latha Anantharaman



THAMODHARAN B



THE TAMILS
A Portrait of a Community
by Nirmala Lakshman
ALEPH
₹999; 464 pages